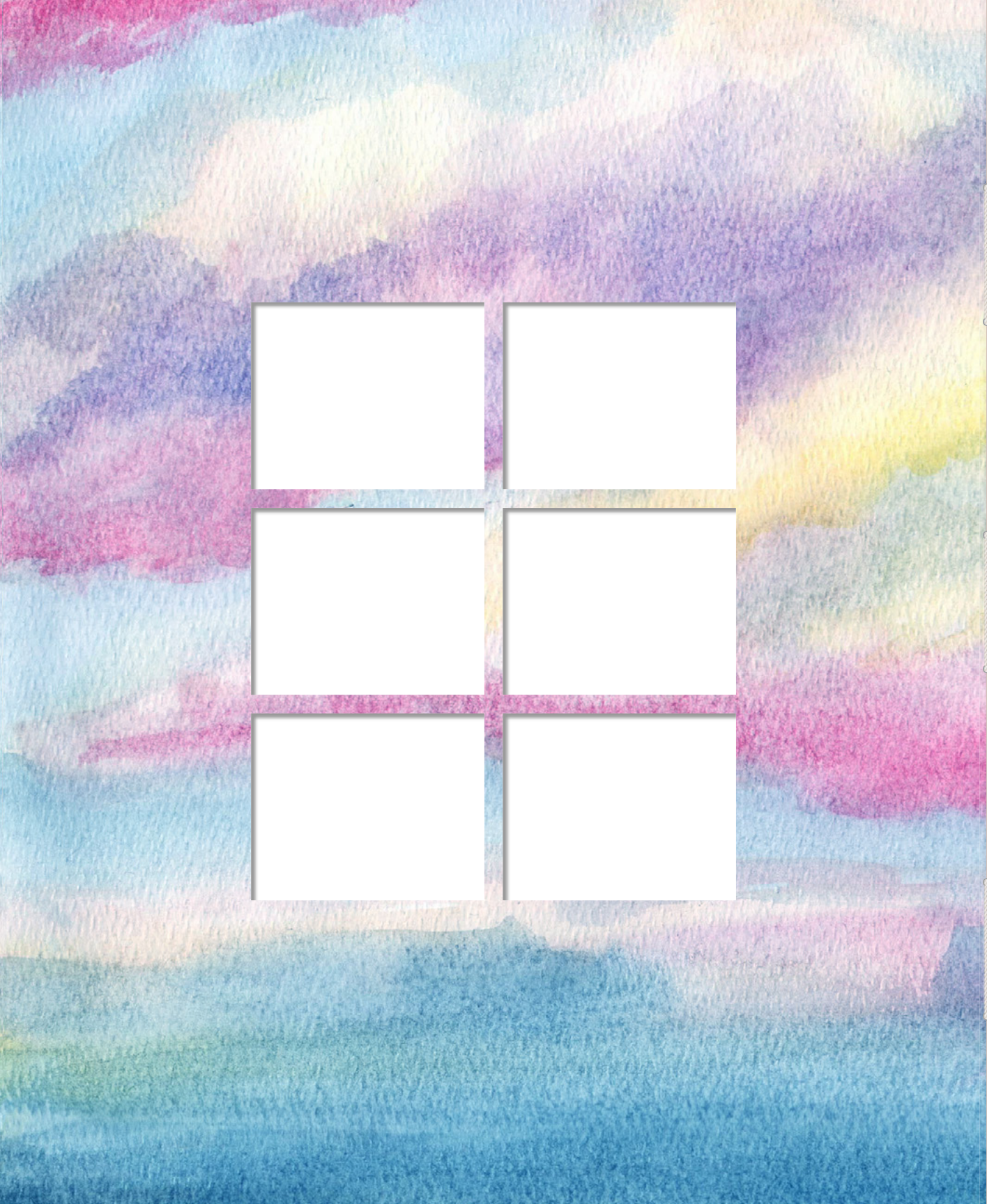








# Between The Clouds

Written, Illustrated, and Designed By Arkara Boonthong



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Unlike Math or Biology, where I have to set aside time to absorb the subject, writing is something that I'm constantly doing, on the train ride from school, eating dinner, or lazing about in my bed, under the Saturday morning sun. In my brain, I'm churning out sentence fragments, little phrases that make me go "that sounds nice" internally. It's something I've always remembered doing, even when I wasn't fully aware of it. There's no prompt, no trigger, this ability of mine just is. Words and sentences reverberate throughout my brain until I can't take it anymore and they either get written down or repurposed, retooled into a different piece. They're never forgotten, nor do they ever leave my head. They just sit in the back of my mind patiently, just waiting to be used. In elementary school, I thought I hated writing, that I wasn't creative and had no idea what to write about, or how to make it in the least was interesting. When I started reading more, I found that authors can put so much weight their words, and add deeper complexity to their art, something I wanted to do. *The Night Circus* by Erin Morgenstern has been one of my favorite examples of this, the language is so beautiful and descriptive, the images line up perfectly in the back of my brain. It was also my first real plunge into reading—and subsequently writing, my first introduction into the world of storytelling. I'm an eclectic writer just as I am an eclectic artist, I have no real set notebook or sketchbook, rather phrases and doodles get scrawled down anywhere they can, like post-its, napkins, or even handouts given to me in class. I feel that with the constantly expanding nature of thoughts, it's hard to confine them into a single space and that they pop into my head and vanish faster than I can whip out a notebook. The one I've kept this year is really a small percentage of what goes on internally, a good deal of words exist outside the book, and a million more go unused within my head. It's a photo taken of a video that stretches on forever and ever, the plethora of thoughts before and after go unnoticed, what makes it into the book being what I had in my mind at that very moment. I feel like without writing as a creative outlet I would have gone insane, especially this semester, with the need to write college essays growing and growing. Writing is exasperating for sure, that search for the perfect word has me practically married to the thesaurus. But it also gives me a chance to indulge in my melodrama, to embrace my inner emo and satisfy my need for angst. Perhaps that's why it finds it so satisfying when a piece pulls itself together when it gets to the point where I can climb up to the highest rooftop and shout "Hey world! This is my writing!". When you finish a piece it's the ultimate payoff.



# The Inner Vitality to a Sea of Brown

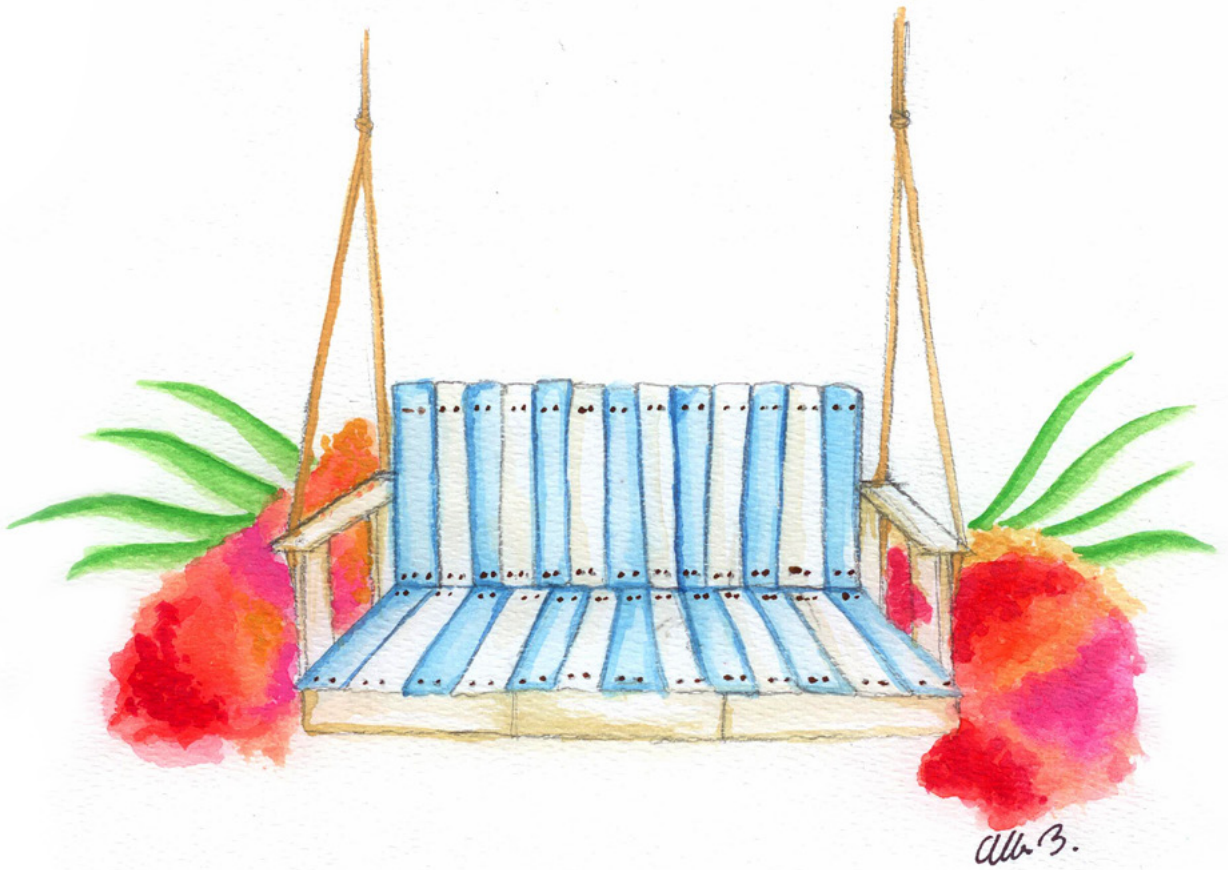
My older sister and I are more alike than we would like to admit. We have this fastidious nature, this need to be surrounded by color and light, an aversion to the monotonous and drab. That nature was reflected in the clothes we wore, the things we owned, and the decor in our rooms. Mother would say that's why we could never stay in the same place for too long. The similarity of our energies would exhaust the two of us until one of us would have to inevitably leave. Despite this, a kid I would spend all my time in her room, watching TV with her, or sitting idle in the back while she did her homework. I loved her room. Whenever I was there, I felt a sense of weightlessness, like I was flying far above the earth, immersed in the clouds. The soft whites and light blues reflected the morning sun, bathing the space in an ivory glow. It was like a commercial for air freshener, exuding crispness and freshness.

A stark contrast to her airy bedroom lay outside the sliding doors to the right wall. Unlike the dreamy terraces of Pinterest with elaborate stonework and curling fronds of wrought iron, her balcony was a tiny beige structure where I could take two steps and reach the other side, my toes curling up the front. Rather than intricate fencing, it was wholly bricked off, save for a steel railing that lay over the top. It was the essence of uninteresting, the personification of the word "bland."

I remember how it detracted from the room, how it undermined the pastels she allowed to dominate the space. I looked back at it whenever I was in there, sitting in her lap while she did her homework, or side by side while we watch movies. It was a severe break from the bedspread, the floors, the walls, even the picture frames propped up from cubic shelves. Amidst all this color, this light, was a terracotta eyesore, something that immediately drew focus, and like the worst attention whore, didn't want to let it go.

The balcony dimmed that spark she had inside, like it was siphoning her essence away. The grey of the steel and muddy browns of the bricks seemed to drain her





of her color. She looked deathly pale, her hair a mousy umber, her eyes an abysmal black. It repulsed me, what it did to her, how it took my vibrant, energetic sister and diminished what made her special.

It wasn't until the arrival of a gardener hired by my grandmother to spruce up the house that the balcony underwent its grand metamorphosis. The browns were drowned out in a welcome deluge of whites and grays, the bricks covered by gravel and stepping stones in these mixed colors. The walls were covered in pewter pots holding an abundance of various silk flowers, an incandescent array of pinks, yellows, and oranges. Glass jars that were retooled into lanterns were placed around the pots, and on the whitewashed nightstand that had been rebirthed as a table for this miniature garden. But the crowning glory was a porch swing parked on the leftmost side of

the balcony, the once dark wood painted in her signature stripes of blue and cream.

I remember sitting back amidst the flowers, stretching out my tiny legs, and unraveling into the atmosphere. The lines and edges of the balcony, the swing, even the gravel all seem to diffuse under the pleasant heat of the sun. It's like I've crossed over into an alternate world, a novel fairyland, or a watercolor painting, somewhere frothy, somewhere light. The moment I stepped out of the sliding window doors, I felt immersed in something new, a vast world in a teeny tiny balcony. When I think about the balcony before, the harsh tawny browns and cold steel, I marvel at how much warmth and welcoming energy has been poured into it, overflowing and dribbling down the sides, and how the gardener fit an entire dimension into such a tiny space. I wanted to keep that place with me forever, like my childhood I wanted to cling fast to it and try my hardest not to let go. I remember sitting with my sister the night the remodel was finished, her legs dangling over the sides of the swing, while only my bony shins made it past the edge. The change in the balcony had revitalized her within, I saw it as plain as the calm smile on her face, the waning sun creating a halo of gold in her chocolate brown hair. We didn't talk, but we didn't need to. When we locked eyes, we already had a thousand conversations, in a language only we could speak, only we could understand. My lips were chapped, glued together from the inside. How long had we been staring at each other? She inched closer to me. *What are you thinking about?* She says, *I'm not sure*, I reply. She tells me I look tired and pats her shoulder, an invite for me to lean on it. My head is a bit sweaty from the July sun, but if she notices it, she doesn't tell.

*It's nice here.* I relax, and my head makes its way to her shoulder as her hand wraps around my tiny frame. I smell the plumeria flowers from the garden, blown in by the summer breeze. My eyelids droop. This would be a nice place to sleep. So I do, my head resting on her shoulder, dozing off to the gentle creak of the swing, as we rock back and forth in the summer night.



# The Second-degree Burns That Come With Remembering Too Much

Ever since I was little, there were specific rules I had to follow: be kind to others, always help those in need, and never put yourself in danger. I remember not being allowed near the scissors, the sewing machine, and most importantly, the stove in the kitchen. I remember my parents warning me not to touch it, “It’s hot, and you’ll burn yourself,” they said. I remember doing it anyway, and the searing pain that followed even after I yanked my hand back. I remember the welt that formed shortly after, ugly and painful, taking up the better part of my thumb, and filled with a mysterious yellowish liquid. I also remember constantly rubbing until it finally popped, the pus running in rivulets down my fingers. The burning in my hands vanished, but I’ll carry the marks for years to come.

Twelve years later, I look down at my hand. It’s unblemished, but the memory—and the pain associated with it—remains. I’m at home and it’s a Saturday evening between lunch and dinner, and my brain wanders once more to my elementary school on the Upper West Side. I can’t help it, and I never seem to know why this one memory rushes back to me, time and time again, but I’m helpless to stop it, as my traitorous brain sends me stumbling back into Mr. Williams’s third-grade game of mafia. I’m excited, I really like this game, and it was always fun to hang out with my friends. Zoe (who I didn’t really talk to that much), tells everyone to put their heads down, and I do so, heart racing, palms sweaty, praying to anyone who was listening that I wouldn’t be the mafia. When Zoe tells everyone to pick their heads up I’m relieved, she hasn’t chosen me. By the time the game starts I’m feeling confident, and victory seems within my clammy grasp. On the first round, Cameron was killed, better him than me. However, it’s from here the stressful part begins. My classmates point fingers at one another, and accusations fly left and right. Luckily, nothing is aimed towards me, so I sit back, and watch the class pet Pumpkin Bear in his cage.

I wonder what he thinks about, what he does when I’m not around. The two of us have a staring contest. He’s a snake, so of course, he wins.





By the time two more innocent suspects are hauled off to jail and the third round rolls around, everyone seems more wary of one another, and a clear hierarchy amongst the remaining townspeople has emerged. Everything falls quiet for a moment, when Maya, the unofficial leader of the squadron and the most confident in herself, says “Arkara’s looking kind of shift.” Everyone’s eyes immediately lock on me. Aaron, Brooke, and Dominic, who never travel without each other, fall in line in immediately and point their fingers at me.

“... hasn’t said anything or accused anyone”

“...probably killed Cameron, too.”

“... it’s got to be him.”

I feel my throat tightening up, as Mr. Williams makes his verdict.

“Oh, Arkara’s been sentenced to ten years of hard labor!”

My heart is pounding, you can barely swallow, and tears are forcing their way out, threatening to roll down my cheeks. *No! It’s not fair! Why are they accusing me?* I think. I run from my chair, and hear the clang as it hits the ground behind me. I don’t stop running until I’m in the bathroom, and I’ve locked myself inside. I try splashing water on my face to calm myself down, but I can’t stop crying, my chest heaving and nose running from the strength of my sobs. I slide down the wall into a crouching position on the floor, feeling the cold tile against my back. I wish my life was simpler, that it was me coiled under the fake log. Maybe I wouldn’t be so sad right now. Perhaps then, everything would be okay. I don’t know why I’m in here, you just know that I’m not coming out. Not until someone apologizes. Who and for what, I’m not sure. But it’s gotta happen. It’s gotta. There’s a knock on the door, and I can hear Zoe’s voice from the other end.

“You okay?”

*Go away!* I try to scream at her, but you can’t, because your throat is still wet and you’re still wheezing.

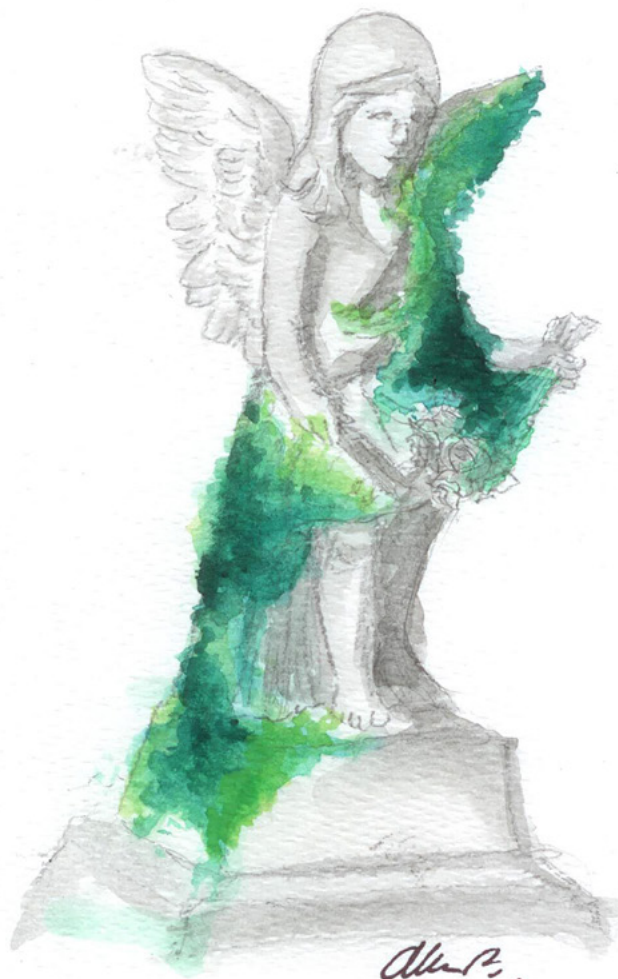
“I think we might have something that’ll make you feel better,” she says.

I rise to my feet, legs still shaky, and as best I can, I jiggle the doorknob free. Zoe said that while I was in the bathroom, the class decided to send me to jail for one night, and then I can rejoin the game like nothing ever happened. Of course, I'm overjoyed and eagerly accept the deal. And while I'm in jail for the one night, I see Tyreek and Tiffany raise their heads and take out Maya. *Good, I think. She deserves it.* I then announce the identities of the mafia to the class like some sort of valiant hero, and with that, the game is over. As the years go by, the memory no longer seems a very good one. With time, it spoils, curdles, sours. With that deal I made, I ended the game. I ruined it for everyone else. I could've just gone to jail, and none of this would've happened. My classmates had to bend over backward to accommodate me, costing them the game. I often wish I could spatula the thought out of my mind and chuck it into the whirring blades of the garbage disposal. It's a testament to my selfishness, sensitivity, and stubbornness, something I'll have to keep learning from again and again. So I'm trying my hardest to think of others, and whenever I slip, my mind immediately falls back there, to that third-grade classroom. In a way, that vision of my past could just as easily be one of my future. And it terrifies me. So every night, I pray that this memory will someday gather dust and sink to the farthest recesses of my mind, where I'll never have to think about it again, but most likely it never will.

Memories can have the same effect as burning your hand, especially the ones you can't get out of your head, of a past you want to deny ever existed, and every time you revisit it, relive it, it burns part of your soul. That memory became my brand new stove, piping hot, and excruciatingly painful. But rather than instantly yank my hand away, I leave it there and let my flesh get seared by the fires of memory. It's been over seven years, and I still think back to that game of mafia. It's that little devil on my shoulder, whispering into my ear of who not to be again, to curb me in the right direction.

My brain catapults you back to reality, to that same Saturday evening, in between lunch and dinner. This time, as my hand hovers above the stove, I bite the bullet and thrust it forward.

And for the first time ever, it doesn't burn.





# The Worst Kind of Rebirth

I can't pinpoint it exactly, the day I died. Somehow, I just remember a time when I was alive, and a time I wasn't, there was no defining moment in between, no grand event that tore my soul from my body forever. Death is supposed to be quick, right? At least that's what I see on TV when writers decide to kill a beloved character purely for shock value. It's usually fast, easy, and if it's painful, it's only for a moment. So how come when I died, it felt so long? So drawn out, like I was having every last drop of life wrung out of me like a dirty rag?

When I was alive, I had this fire for every experience and an obsession for life that permeated my being. I was the personification of curiosity, eagerly absorbing information be it crucial or meaningless, so I could better appreciate the world around me. My eyes were perpetually sewn open, in awe of everything world had to offer.

When I entered elementary school, my idyllic mentality had begun to wither. There I met a girl. She had this magnetic energy that drew people toward her, and she commanded the room as best as a twelve-year-old could. She said she wanted to be a star, that she wanted to sing in front of large crowds of adoring fans. She had somehow taken a liking to me and decided I should be part of her entourage. At recess, we would walk around the playground and sing. I was okay with it at first, then weeks passed and I found myself yearning for the thrill of the swings, the precarious danger of the monkey bars, but I never said anything. Not to her, or myself. I pushed down my inner longing for autonomy and masked it with the appreciation of being liked, of belonging. Slowly, I began to adopt her characteristics. I made the same gestures, loved the same things, even my voice changed, and I articulated words just like her. My mother repeatedly told me I had changed, asking me when had I become such a pushover. She chastised me for Going to the theatre to see *The Hunger Games*, a book series I vehemently hated but my new friend loved, just to spend time with her. I accused her of trying to ruin my social life, when she was really trying to stop me from compromising myself for someone else's sake. The worst part was that I made

myself believe I was happy with her. The person I was, who I used to be, was dying.

It was only when I had reached middle school, far away from her grasp, that I finally started to feel used. When one of the boys at my table told me I was a whiny teenage girl trapped in a boy's body, something inside me broke. I had never taken a look at my actions before, and only through this reflection did I see the magnitude of her influence on me. I realized that she had never liked me for who I was, but for the person she could turn me into. It was the worst kind of awakening, where instead of being gently shaken, I had scalding hot water thrown in my face, searing my skin and my soul along with it. I withdrew into myself, scared that if I let anyone close someone would waltz in and control me again like a marionette. I became caustic, my tongue a stinging barb I would continuously use against others for no reason. Like a dying star, I was a ball of searing hot rage that couldn't sustain itself for long. And like all dying stars, I eventually winked out of existence, fizzling out into nothing. My rage, sadness, and resent toward the world had dimmed, along with my capacity for experiencing joy the way I did before. The person I was had died, and reborn in his place was a dry husk, devoid of many of the traits that made him special.

In death I feel like I'm only halfway-conscious; my heart beats, my eyes blink, my palms sweat, but behind my eyes, lies a vast field of nothing, like a forest after its been razed to the ground by fire. It's not your typical indifference, but characterized by this desensitization to the vibrancy of emotion, like I'm living life behind a one-way mirror, witnessing the joy and exhilaration on the faces of the people I meet but never being able to join them. They'll never find me because I'm hidden by darkened glass, so they'll never really be there to pull me into their light. How can they, when the person I used to be, a person I would give anything to be again, was buried six feet under with no hope of escaping? Sometimes I'd skip meals then stuff my face sometime later because there's nothing else to do. Like a zombie, I roam the earth with no clear purpose, with no aim, and certainly no capacity for empathy. Many of my friends regard pain as the worst feeling imaginable. It isn't. How can anything be worse than this eternal silence inside of me?

Death is something touted as inevitable, like the water in our faucet making its way back to the sea, or the sun growing bloated in its final years, consuming the earth in a fiery inferno. But my death could have, should have, been avoided. Every night I think about the things I could have done, the ways I could have cheered myself up, anything to be anyone else from who I am now. The last thing I wanted to do was compromise myself, to become someone I didn't recognize. When we lose sight of who we are, we kill the person we used to be, allowing a new one to take their place. When life draws to a close, when the petals of a flower shrivel and are cast to the wind, when a bird exhales for the last time and descends to the ground, there's a new beginning, a rebirth. In my shallow grave, my soul has petrified, but the seeds of a new person atop the proverbial soil blossom, reaching for the sun.

# Through the Looking Glass to the Places That Lay Beyond

## **Part 1: There Isn't Much Use for a Book Without Pictures**

I remember I made my first landscape painting when I was in first grade. It wasn't anything fancy, just a green rectangle for the earth, a yellow circle for the sky, and little V-shaped birds in the distance, all hastily scribbled in the most vivid colors I could find. I was so proud of my Crayola masterpiece back then. To me, it was the absolute pinnacle of my achievement. Looking back on it nine years later, the cheapness and lack of imagination are more apparent than ever, but that Crayola drawing was the stepping point into a more creative part of my psyche, it was the tiny little door I crawled through on my hands and knees into a garden of endless possibility.

Nowadays, most of my landscape paintings are done with depth, lighting and more color than I ever thought possible. With a few flicks of a brush, I can create a dense forest or a cozy bedroom. But since my creative awakening, I've dived further and further away from the mundane subjects taught in all my art classes: gesture drawings of human bodies holding precarious poses, or soporific still-life paintings that attempt to capture the fathoms of a piece of fruit. My forests are full of purple trees and fish that swim through the air, and my bedrooms have coral growing from the ceilings, with banded sea-snakes wrapped around them. Many see these kind of paintings as purely fluff, an embellishment that holds no deeper meaning, and is just there for aesthetic purposes. But fantasy art holds much more than that, it's an expression of my thoughts, emotions, intuitions, and desires, but also about sharing what I see when I close my eyes and swim in the oceans of my subconscious. The more outlandish the painting, the more dear it is to my heart. Each work contains a fragment of my soul, tucked between layer upon layer of paint.





## Part 2: It Doesn't Matter Which Way You Go If You Don't Much Care Where You Want to Get To

Whenever I would take a vacation, relaxation-based destinations like Cancun or the Bahamas never blipped on my radar. With a million different worlds swirling inside my head, the vacation spots lauded by my friends and various travel agencies seemed trivial, flat, boring. Instead, I wanted to go somewhere that could take me as close as I possibly could to the realm of fantasy. Ever since I was six, theme parks have been a kind of sanctuary for me, a place where I feel the same effervescent euphoria that permeated my daydreams. The inherent artificiality of a theme park is perhaps what draws me in the most, how people carefully craft environments with the aim to transport you someplace else, be it Hogwarts, or Pandora from Avatar. The theming is designed to create something far-fetched and bring it to the forefront of reality, like

the floating islands of an alien planet or a goblin-run bank.

I remember on my second trip to Universal Studios, we stayed at the Loews Portofino Bay Hotel, which was a breathtaking visual spectacle of a beautiful harbor, with colorful buildings in various shades of pinks, yellows, and peaches lining the shore. The resort oozed this opulent energy that permeated my very being, and staying there, I felt transported over 4000 miles away. Coupled with the excitement of a theme park, the resort became an enchanted locale that made me lose interest in visiting the real Portofino Bay in Italy, for it could not have possibly held the same amount of wonder a theme park can provide.

### **Part 3: With So Many Out-of-the-way Things Happening Every Day, Very Few Things Are Really Impossible**

Birthered from my daydreams, my fantasy worlds were the ultimate form of escape from the doldrums of everyday life. With every outlandish landscape painting, every trip to Disney World and Universal Studios, I found myself slipping away from the real and tangible. The deeper I fell down the rabbit hole of fantasy, the duller reality became, and the more gray and bland the real world seemed to be. During the winter months, my life was reduced to learning formulas or writing papers in an endless repetition of wake up, go to school, come home. I craved the freedom of leaving behind the repetitiveness that seems irritatingly shackled to working life. It was through my daydreams, I could do anything I wanted, and the things I could do were as limitless as my imagination would allow.

My contentment to be off in my own wonderland has gotten me in trouble before, I've been yelled at for zoning out, and for my lack of focus. It was much easier to pretend to be somewhere else, where cats and rabbits dressed in shoes, hats, and trousers reside in fancy little houses, and the running of a brook is a song I can understand. When the real world hurts too much, daydreaming is the ultimate escape. There's not a lot of room for imagination in calculus or physics, subjects that are as straightforward and direct as the books that go with them. But a clinical book

without pictures does not have much use to me. Without daydreaming, I would have cracked like a pistachio and flattened by the hydraulic pressure of this world. It's my buffer, an oasis in my mind that I planted myself, down to the last flower. My deepest desire is to live in the worlds I've made for myself, but many of my daydreams stay just that, dreams, and I can't physically enter no matter how much I want to. One day I might wander somewhere exciting, someplace that looks like I could have painted it with my own brush. When I get there, I'll be sure to soak up every last detail and preserve it in my mind forever.

I'll repeat that mantra like six impossible things before breakfast.

## From Prompt to Piece: The Making of “The Inner Vitality to a sea of Brown”

I am by all means a big fan of flowery prose, and that’s evident in this essay. I must’ve packed metaphors and imagery here like sardines, because I just wanted to put across just how much that place meant to me. When I got the prompt to write about place, I really didn’t know what to write about. I wanted to keep it simple, if I had written about a location like Disney World, I would have died from how much detail I needed to encompass, and of which of the multitude of themed areas I wanted to write about. I settled on my sister’s balcony instead, it being small, yet holding so much meaning behind it. I felt like with this topic, I could also go into the relationship between the two of us, and how much she means to me. Like a lot of my pieces, my first draft was a disaster. Originally, my first sentence was “It wasn’t a big balcony by any means”, which would’ve acted as a gateway into the negative aspects of the place, but looking back, it was too jarring of a start. It also neglected the main aspect of the piece—my sister. After all, it was her balcony I was writing about. My conclusion was also extremely unsatisfying with me saying something along the lines of “after the makeover, it was pretty. I liked that”. In class, one of the freewriting prompts was to take a sentence from somewhere else in our essay and turn it into the first sentence. I chose “The two of us are more alike than we would like to admit”, a direct reference to my sister, and why she and her room mean so much to me. The rest of the essay fell into place shortly after, with this freewrite leading me on the path to formulating a more anecdotal conclusion that I was satisfied with.



the building, blanketing the land in green  
once more.

10/23

Aim: What does specificity add to our writing and  
how do we nail it in our essays of place?

~~My head resting on her shoulder, and the  
gentle creak of the sun, as we rock back and  
forth in the summer night.~~ **move to end**

When I think of the balcony <sup>today</sup>, I feel a sense of calm.

I sit back amidst the sea of reds and oranges and  
pinks of the silk flowers, and just melt into the  
landscape. My world becomes hazy, the lines and  
edges of the balcony, the edges of the sun, the  
edges of the gravel all seem to diffuse under  
this all encompassing light of the sun. I think

that I've crossed over into an alternate  
world, like I've stepped into a watercolor  
painting or a conversation for a fresher, a  
place ~~brothy~~, a place of light. I think  
about the balcony before, the harsh tawny browns  
and cold steel, and marvel at how much warmth  
and welcoming energy has been poured into it,  
virtually overflowing and dribbling down the sides.

I want to keep this place with me forever, like  
my childhood, I wanted to cling hard to it and  
try my hardest not to let go. I want to  
ingrain the thoughts into my brain [I see my



Sister now, her legs dangling over the sides of the  
swing, while only my shins peek past the  
edge. I see the calm smile on her face, the breeze  
letting the sun shine on her chocolate brown hair.  
We don't talk, but we don't need to. When we  
lock eyes we already have a myriad of  
conversations, and eons go by in a matter of minutes.  
I taste the saliva in my throat. My lips are  
chapped, and I feel her fingers gently caressing  
through my hair. How long have we been staring at  
each other? It's nice, I relax, and my head nuzzles  
its way to her shoulder as her hand wraps  
around my tiny little shoulders. I smell the plumera  
from the garden, blown in by the summer breeze.  
My eyelids droop. This would be a nice place to  
sleep. So I do. [ ]

Insert.

Ann: How can "playing with a draft unlock potential new routes for the essay

*Move to hegemony*

**NFL** The two of us are more alike than we'd like to admit...

We have this fastidious nature, ~~this need to be surrounded by color and light, an aversion to the bland and drab.~~ That choice was reflected in our rooms, in the colors we wore, and the things we owned.

*of pinterest*

I never liked how tiny the balcony was. Unlike the dreamy terraces with elaborate stonework and curling fronds of wrought iron, ~~of pinterest~~, my sister's balcony was a tiny beige structure where ~~you~~ could take 2 steps across the width and reach the other side, your toes curling up the frontmost wall... ~~By all means~~ it was the essence of uninteresting, a personification of the word "bland."

~~Rather than intricate fencing, the balcony was~~  
Bricked off from all 3 sides, save for a steel railing that lay over top

# Blurbs

*Arkara's use of imagery and metaphors never fail to paint a vivid, detailed picture. His use of words livens up his pieces and makes anything he writes about feel larger-than-life. His writing is brimming with emotion, and you can see how much of himself Arkara put into his work. As a result, after reading his essays you feel like you really understand Arkara, which is something only truly great writers can accomplish.*

- George McBarron

*Reading Arkara's work is like being sucked into the page in his shoes. He is able to combine emotion and sensory details in a manner that is extremely relatable and personal for readers (even if you have never had an experience remotely similar to what he is describing). The simplest, yet most effective way to describe Arkara's writing is that he is absolutely fearless in his approach to writing, resulting in extremely powerful literature.*

- Reed Scheinberg



Dear Arkara,

Thank you for putting SO much of your time, self, and talents into this final collection. It was a joy and pleasure to flip through, revisit some of my favorite moments, encounter new ones, all the while getting a treat to the eyes with your artwork.

You have a knack for titles, let me tell ya! So many people just don't *get it*, but you do, in spades. George totally nailed it with "brimming with emotion" and Reed is on point with "resulting in extremely powerful literature." I hope you continue reading, writing, nourishing your garden of talents, so that other readers like me will be gifted the same (and greater) delight.

And thank you for being a consistently engaged contributor to our class community.

Sincerely,  
Ms. Pohan









